

THE BA API REQUIREMENT CHECKLIST

The questions that turn a vague API ask into a requirement developers and QA can build from.

STRIP AWAY THE JARGON

System A asks System B for something.

Using a contract both sides already agreed on. That's the whole idea — the rest is naming parts of it.

1 PURPOSE & CONSUMER

What is this API for, in one sentence? Who calls it, when, how often?

2 ENDPOINT & METHOD

What's being asked for — GET, POST, PUT/PATCH or DELETE?

3 REQUEST FIELDS

What's sent, and which fields are actually mandatory?

4 VALIDATION

What makes a request invalid, specifically?

5 RESPONSE & STATUS CODES

What comes back, and what does each status code mean here?

6 ERROR BEHAVIOUR

What should the user see for each possible error?

7 AUTH vs AUTHORISATION

Who's calling, and what are they allowed to do?

8 TIMEOUT & RETRY

What happens if it's slow, and is it safe to resend?

9 DUPLICATES & DOWNSTREAM

What if the same request arrives twice, and who else relies on the response?

10 AUDIT & VERSIONING

Does this need logging? Is this a new version or a breaking change?

BEFORE YOU CALL THE REQUIREMENT DONE

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| ☐ Purpose written in one sentence | ☐ Mandatory vs. optional fields decided |
| ☐ Status codes mapped to this requirement | ☐ Error responses defined per case |
| ☐ Authentication and authorisation both addressed | ☐ Timeout and retry behaviour decided |
| ☐ Duplicate-request behaviour decided | ☐ Downstream consumers identified |

REMEMBER

You don't need to build the API. You need to know what to ask about it.

Every API requirement reduces to: what's asked for, what comes back, what happens on failure, and who else depends on the answer staying the same.